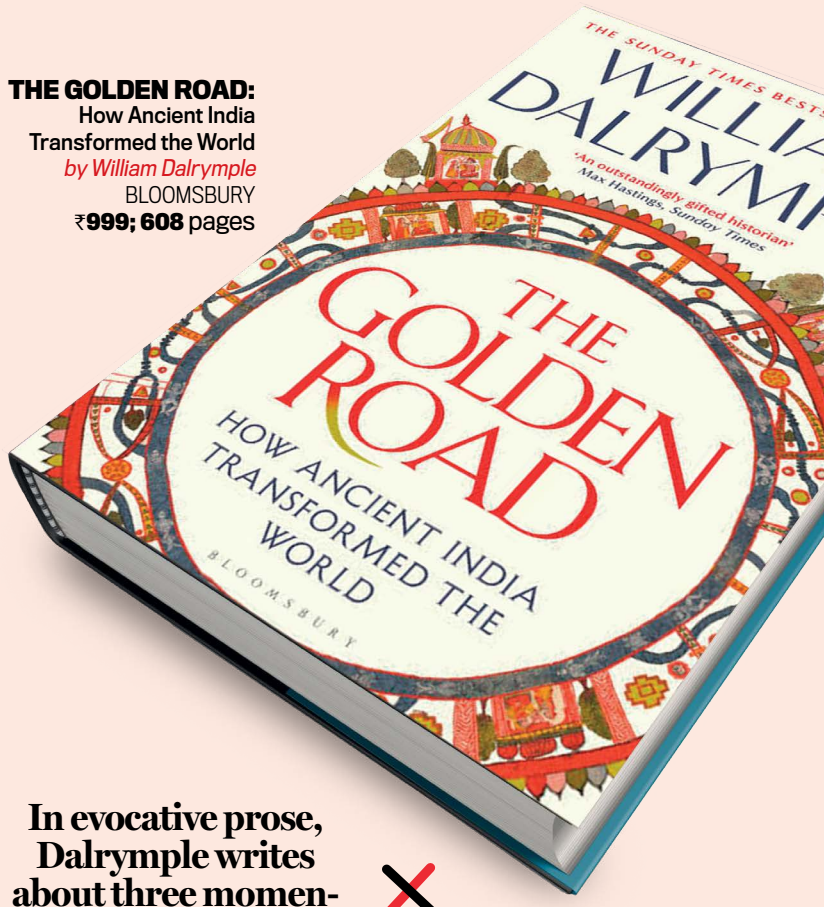
THE GOLDEN ROAD:
How Ancient India Transformed the World
by William Dalrymple
BLOOMSBURY
₹**999; 608** pages



In evocative prose, Dalrymple writes about three momentous manifestations of India's soft power

Until 1877, there was nothing known as the Silk Road, even though the ancient trade route linking East and West over 6,400 kms certainly existed. And, until 2024, the Golden Road didn't feature in any vocabulary. But now, thanks to celebrated historian and author William Dalrymple's latest book titled *The Golden Road*, we have a name for the route that resulted in the diffusion of religion, culture, trade and science from India to a wide swathe of the world—China, Southeast Asia, West and Central Asia and on to Europe—between 250 BCE to 1200 CE. On a "slightly dystopian Delhi winter evening" (his description!) Dalrymple tells us why calling it the Golden Road seemed so apt, "It's all about gold: Roman gold coming in from the West, and then the pivot Eastwards to Suvarnabhumi, the Lands of Gold. It also sounds wonderfully resonant...like an idea that has always been there."

The Golden Road (*TGR*) takes his considerable fan following in a new direction. Dalrymple spent 20 years writing The Company Quartet, his four-volume deep dive into the rise and fall of the East India Company. Even if finishing the quartet wasn't reason enough, the passing of his close collaborator, Persian translator and polymath Bruce Wannell four months after *Anarchy* was released, sealed it tragically. Which is perhaps why, though his podcast 'Empire' still delved into the subject, he was able to move on as a writer and go back to what he calls "his original love", which was always ancient history.

In *TGR*, taking the enlightened middle path between bland Marxist history and that of the revivalist right, Dalrymple is definitive in identifying and essaying in evocative prose three momentous manifestations of India's soft power—the diffusion of Buddhism, Hinduism and scientific knowledge. His research revealed that, given India's unique position as a maritime trading power radiating east and west, it wasn't a military that propelled this pollination. "In almost all periods of history, most ideas travel with armies. But on the Golden Road, they all travelled with traders and missionaries," he points out.

Dalrymple marvels that there aren't too many other books on these lines. "There's lots of very strong micro-scholarship. What this book does is pull all the available material together. Astonishingly, I don't think that there's been a book like this since A.L. Basham's *The Wonder that was India* in 1954," he says. It was a chance trip to the Ajanta Caves in 2015 that kindled the idea. In caves 9 and 10, which are about 600 years older than all the others from 550 CE, Dalrymple discovered some extraordinary frescoes which he'd never seen before. "It turns out that they're the oldest Buddhist frescoes in the world! At that point, I was aware that there was a whole world in the story of early Buddhism," he shares.

Uncharacteristically, he hasn't started his next book. Coming off four months on the road with a global book tour and off for a holiday in Vietnam that he's looking forward to, Dalrymple's still considering what he plans to do next. He's signed up with Bloomsbury for four more titles. "The idea was to write on the opium wars. But I so enjoyed Amitav Ghosh's trilogy and two other brilliant books on the subject (Stephen Platt's *Imperial Twilight* and Julia Lovell's *The Opium War*) that I'm